remains: is there a way of making sense of Ashoka's unhappy twilight years from these sources that are for such purposes dubious?

We don't for a start know exactly how many years elapsed from the last edict in the twenty-seventh year after his coronation to the year of his death. His end is surmised as having happened less than ten years after the last edict from 'dates' mentioned in the *Mahavamsa* of Sri Lanka, a text dated to the fifth century CE. The twentieth chapter of this work provides a summary description of Ashoka's last years in the form of a kind of regnal calendar:

> In the eighteenth year (of the reign) of king Dhammasoka, the great Bodhi-tree was planted in the Mahameghavanarama. In the twelfth year afterwards died the dear consort of the king, Asamdhimitta, the faithful (believer) in the Sambuddha. In the fourth year after this the ruler of the earth Dhammasoka raised the treacherous Tissarakka to the rank of queen. In the third year thereafter this fool, in the pride of her beauty, with the thought: 'Forsooth, the king worships the great Bodhi-tree to my cost!' drawn into the power of hate and working her own harm, caused the great Bodhi-tree to perish by means of a mandu-thorn. In the fourth year after did Dhammasoka of high renown fall into the power of mortality. These make up thirty seven years.[1]

If these years are totalled, the events seem to have transpired across some forty-one years and not thirty-seven. However, Ananda Guruge points out that a later commentary on this text explains each year in its account after calculating it twice—as both the preceding and the succeeding year: thus the figure of thirty-seven years. This would mean that there was a gap of some eight years between the death of Ashoka's queen Asamdhimitta (in the twenty-ninth year from his consecration) and Ashoka's death (in the thirty-seventh year from his consecration).[2] Asamdhimitta died, it appears, in 241 BCE within a year from the time the emperor issued his Seventh Pillar Edict. If this is what happened, grief and personal preoccupations may have prevented the composing of further edicts.

While the corroboration of calendrical exactitude in the *Mahavamsa* is a difficult matter, the condensed way in which it provides the information—